**Appendix 5. Visual NMCC Markers on the Korean Peninsula and in the British Isles**

**Figure 5: NMCC – Comparative Visual Evidence from the Korean Peninsula and the British Isles**


**Note:** While the main body of this study focuses on spatial and symbolic alignments across Neolithic sites on the Korean Peninsula and in the British Isles, Figure 5 provides supplementary comparative material that may enrich future interdisciplinary interpretations. This includes a curated set of visual evidence from the Korean Peninsula (A–D) and the British Isles (E–H), showcasing symbolic and structural markers—such as cup marks, cup-and-link motifs, kurgan-type mounds, and shell midden deposits—commonly associated with the core components of the NMCC: NCPP, NMS, and LBC. These materials were primarily documented through museum exhibitions, archaeological signage, local brochures, and direct field visits conducted by the author. In cases where formal publications were unavailable, interpretations are based on visual observation, field notes, and comparative pattern analysis. Although not directly analysed in the present study, these markers may indicate broader trans-regional convergences within Neolithic and early Bronze Age cultural systems.

**Figure 5A.** Cup marks engraved on the capstone of a Bronze Age dolmen in Garye-myeon, Uiryeong County (Korean Peninsula). This capstone, measuring approximately 3 m in width, 3.4

m in length, and 1.6 m in height, features at least twelve cup marks carved into its upper surface. These markings are widely interpreted as symbolic traces—possibly linked to ritual practices or agrarian star charts. The image was generated with AI assistance based on archaeological reports and site documentation.

**Figure 5B.** Engraved cup-and-link motif from Dolmen No. 4, Sinae-ri, Miryang (Korean Peninsula). Photographed by Byun Dae-Jung at the Gimhae Museum on 15 November 2019. This engraved flagstone displays a three-tiered concentric circle motif (~7 cm diameter) interpreted as a cup-and-link design, alongside a stylised sword (11.2 cm long, 5.7 cm wide) with an engraved delineation between blade and hilt. Additional engravings on adjacent dolmens suggest anthropomorphic or zoomorphic imagery. Comparable designs have been recorded at Scottish megalithic sites, lending symbolic support to the NMCC hypothesis of a shared cultural vocabulary across regions.

**Figure 5C.** Gaya tumuli cluster, located approximately 25–30 km from the Gadeok site (Korean Peninsula). This funerary complex comprises seven distinct mound groups constructed by polities of the Gaya Confederacy, a network of early states that flourished in the southern Korean Peninsula from the 1st to mid-6th centuries CE. The morphology of these burial mounds bears a notable resemblance to the Marlborough Mound in Wiltshire (British Isles; see Figure 5G), pointing to convergent monumental expressions across distant cultural landscapes. Mound-building traditions—often referred to as *kurgan* in Eurasian archaeology—are exceptionally widespread in Korea, with thousands of examples attesting to long-standing symbolic practices. The image was generated with AI assistance based on archaeological surveys and regional topographic data.

**Figure 5D.** The Dongsamdong Shell Midden, located approximately 20–25 km from the Gadeok site, Busan (Korean Peninsula). This site represents one of the most significant Neolithic shell midden complexes on the Korean Peninsula. Photographed by Byun Dae-Jung at the Busan Museum on 15 November 2019. First identified in 1929 during the Japanese colonial period, the site has since undergone more than ten excavations[1,2]. Stratigraphic analyses suggest prolonged occupation between approximately 8000 and 4000 BP. Artefacts recovered include NCPP ceramics, obsidian sourced from Kyushu, Japan, and pottery associated with the Jōmon tradition—highlighting maritime interaction zones during the early Neolithic.

**Figure 5E.** Bachwen Dolmen, near Caernarfon, Wales (British Isles). This Neolithic dolmen, set in a coastal field near Caernarfon, is composed of a thin, wedge-shaped capstone supported by four upright stones. The monument overlooks the sea and faces the Yr Eifl hills, where the hillfort Tre'r Ceiri is located. The most distinctive feature is the elaborate decoration on the capstone: 110 cup marks and two shallow grooves on the upper surface, with an additional eight cup marks along the eastern edge. The image was generated with AI assistance based on site descriptions and landscape documentation.

**Figure 5F.** Cup-and-ring marked sandstone cliff at Ballochmyle, East Ayrshire, Scotland (British Isles). Photograph by Rosser1954, licensed under CC BY-SA 3.0. This Neolithic or Early Bronze Age carving, discovered in 1986, is among the most extensive cup-and-ring sites in Britain. Its concentric pattern—incised vertically into red sandstone—bears a striking resemblance to the Korean cup-and-link motif (Figure 5B), reinforcing the NMCC's proposition of cross-regional symbolic coherence.

**Figure 5G.** The Marlborough Mound, Wiltshire (British Isles). Also known as Merlin's Mound or Merlin's Mount, this Neolithic monument stands in the town of Marlborough and rises to a height of 19 m (approximately 60 ft), making it the second-tallest prehistoric mound in Britain after Silbury Hill. Modern archaeological investigations date its construction to c. 2400 BCE. The surrounding area contains numerous megalithic features—including dolmens, standing stones, and stone circles—within a 10 km radius, underscoring the ritual saturation of the landscape. Notably, the Marlborough Mound bears a visual resemblance to the Gaya tumuli cluster on the Korean Peninsula (see Figure 5C), suggesting convergent symbolic logic in Neolithic mound-building traditions. The image was generated with AI assistance based on site plans and topographic data.

**Figure 5H.** Pictish shell midden at the Sands of Forvie, Aberdeenshire, Scotland (British Isles). Shell middens and associated occupation layers along both shores of the Ythan Estuary at Forvie have been documented for over a century (Jamieson 1865; Dalrymple 1868). While long attributed to prehistoric activity (e.g. Hawke-Smith 1980; Warren 2005), recent excavations by the University of Aberdeen indicate that at least one midden dates to the Early Medieval period, linked to Pictish occupation. This challenges conventional assumptions about the temporal boundaries of activity in the area. The wider Forvie region contains over 70 Recumbent Stone Circles and multiple Neolithic burial cairns, emphasising the site’s long-term ritual significance. The image was generated with AI assistance based on archaeological literature and environmental survey data.

## References

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